

The State of AI Video: A Practical Workflow for Mid-2025

1. Text-to-Video Isn't There Yet

Full text-to-video generation, while promising, often falls short of professional expectations. The results can be slow to generate, contain visual glitches, and frequently lack the fine-tuned style control needed for high-quality work.

2. The Better Workflow: Image First, Video Second

For greater visual consistency and creative control, the most effective workflow is to first generate a refined still image using a detailed Alpha Prompt. Once the aesthetic, composition, and lighting are locked in, that image can then be animated. This approach ensures the final video aligns perfectly with your intended style.

3. Keep Your Motion Prompt Short and Clear

Complex descriptions are unnecessary for animating an image. A simple, direct motion prompt is most effective. For example:

"Camera pans slowly left to right, soft directional light from above."

This provides clear guidance to the video model without overcomplicating the instructions and introducing potential errors.

4. What Works Well

Current AI video models excel at generating subtle and controlled movements, including:

- **Close-up portraits:** These are consistently the most reliable and highest-quality outputs.
- **Simple motion:** Blinking eyes, a slow head turn, or realistic breathing effects.
- **Atmospheric changes:** Shifting light and shadows.
- **Environmental effects:** Wind, fog, and simple camera movements like a slow push-in or shake.

5. What Doesn't Work Well

The technology still struggles with more complex and dynamic scenes. Common problem areas include:

- **Vehicles:** Cars and other vehicles often glitch, distort, or deform during movement.
- **Complex action:** Actions like breakdancing, flips, or intricate choreography are not yet rendered reliably.
- **Full-body tracking:** Long shots that require tracking a full body in motion remain a significant challenge.

6. Best Tools Right Now (Mid-2025)

- **Veo 3 (Google):** Delivers the highest visual quality and can generate longer clips, though generation times can be slow.
- **Runway Gen-3:** Known for its smooth camera motion and is excellent for fast iteration and testing ideas.
- **Sora (OpenAI):** Produces highly polished, cinematic outputs through a user-friendly chat-based interface, but clips are generally limited to the 10–20 second range.
- **LTX Studio:** The standout choice for animating existing still images and building out scenes with a cohesive flow.

7. Post-Process to Elevate the Result

The raw output from an AI video model is rarely the final product. Always enhance the video in a post-processing application to achieve a professional finish. Key steps include:

- Adding **grain** for a more organic, realistic texture.
- Applying **bloom** to create a cinematic, diffused glow on highlights.
- **Upscaling and color grading** to sharpen the image and ensure the tone matches your project's overall aesthetic.

Even if a video isn't perfect directly from the model, these finishing touches can polish the result and make it feel professional and intentional.